



Humpback whale

Lunge feeder

Length Up to 62 ft (19 m)

Weight Up to 44 tons (40 metric tons)

Habitat or range Worldwide

Given its name for the way it arches its back before diving, the humpback has longer flippers than other whales, and a snout that is covered with bumps called tubercles. It is a rorqual, with an expandable throat that allows it to gulp enormous mouthfuls of prey-filled water. It eats krill and small fish, often rounding them up by blowing walls of bubbles around them and lunging up to engulf an entire school at once.



Minke whale

Expanding throat

Length Up to 33 ft (10 m)

Weight Up to 11 tons (10 metric tons)

Habitat or range Worldwide

The minke is the smallest rorqual whale—a type of baleen whale that feeds by forcing a huge volume of seawater into its mouth and pumping it out through its filtering baleen. Pleats beneath the whale's lower jaw allow its throat to expand to hold the water, which it pumps out with its massive, muscular tongue.



Pygmy right whale

Antarctic krill-feeder

Length Up to 21 ft (6.5 m)

Weight Up to 3.9 tons (3.5 metric tons)

Habitat or range Southern Ocean

This Antarctic whale is the smallest of all the baleen whales, yet it can still weigh twice as much as an average car. It feeds in the cold Southern Ocean, moving north as far as Australia and South Africa as the sea around Antarctica freezes over in winter. It feeds mainly on krill and similar small animals.

Blue whale

Streamlined giant

Length Up to 102 ft (31 m)

Weight Up to 220 tons (200 metric tons)

Habitat or range Worldwide

The biggest animal on the planet, the blue whale is a giant rorqual that feeds in the same way as the minke. It eats mainly shrimplike krill, especially in the Southern Ocean where it can devour 40 million krill a day in summer. Sleek and fast, the blue whale migrates to warmer oceans in winter to breed.

